a FlexLifeFi K-12 program

How to Run This Year

Routines, pacing, FAQ, and the calibration of Cash's voice.

Grade 9 year theme — Entrepreneurship Is Organized Problem-Solving.
The 9-12 band is built for the adults who will scrutinize: parents, teachers, administrators.

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GRADE 09 · TEACHER GUIDE

How to Run This

From flash of inspiration to repeatable discipline.

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For: high-school classroom teachers (typically business/CTE, ELA, social studies, or a dedicated entrepreneurship/financial literacy period), homeschool parents teaching the curriculum, and after-school program leads. Grade 9 is the **first year of the 9-12 band**. This guide assumes some prior Cash to Company exposure (most students will have done Grade 7 or 8); a "year-zero" cohort is fully supported with the bridging notes below. **Companion to:** Grade 9 Curriculum Book, Lesson Plans, Student Activity Book, Cash Video Scripts, and Parent Guide.

WITH CASH - 9-12 VOICE

"Revenue is loud. Contribution margin is true. Compute one number this week."

How this year is built (and why)

> **"Most adults skip this step. You won't."**
>
> - CASH, GRADE 9

Grade 9 of Cash to Company is built around one concrete thing: an Organized Problem-Solving Venture each student carries from September to June. The year teaches four moves on that venture — map the model, discover the customer, model the money, test the bet — and each move is anchored in evidence, not opinion. By June, the student delivers a 7-minute defense covering Canvas v2, customer findings, a 1-year P&L, a 2-week MVP test, and a kill/iterate/scale recommendation.

The pedagogical bones come from three traditions:

- **Understanding by Design.** Big ideas, essential questions, and a year-end performance task drive the planning. Lessons feed the Capstone, not the other way around.
- **Workshop model.** Mini-lesson (10–15 min) → guided work (25–40 min) → confer + close (10 min). Students do most of their thinking on their own work most days.
- **Lean Startup discipline.** The Customer Discovery → MVP Test loop is borrowed directly from Steve Blank and Eric Ries; we've age-leveled the moves but not the rigor.

The shift from middle school to high school is real. The 9-12 band's vocabulary is heavier (unit economics, runway, premortem, MVP, segmentation), Cash speaks in multi-sentence

arguments, and we expect students to defend positions with evidence and concede uncertainty when they don't have it. Grade 9 is where that voice gets installed for the band.

Classroom routines

These run all year. Establish them in the first three weeks and protect them.

Monday — Cash + the Question

A 5-minute Cash video (or printed transcript if no projector) introduces the week's question. Students respond to a one-prompt opener in the Capstone Journal. Whole-class share-out: 2–3 students.

Wednesday — Work Block

The longest block of the week, 50–75 minutes, dedicated to the Capstone. Mini-lesson (10–15) → independent or pair work (35–50) → 5-minute close. Teacher confers with 5–7 students per block in 4-minute one-on-ones.

Friday — Showcase + Stuck

20–25-minute share. Three or four students share progress; one student shares "where I'm stuck"; class generates suggestions using the "What's working / What's confusing / One change I'd try" frame.

Weekly — the Vocabulary Spine

A single-page running glossary at the back of the notebook. Students add 2–4 terms per week with a Frayer entry for "weight-bearing" terms. Tuesday/Thursday have 5-minute vocabulary openers.

Quarterly — Capstone Checkpoint Studio Day

Once per unit (Weeks 8, 18, 28, 36), the regular schedule pauses for a Studio Day — a 90-minute block where students complete and defend the unit's anchor artifact. These days are the year's load-bearing assessments; protect them on the calendar.

Pedagogy at this grade band

- **Concrete, then abstract.** Even at high school, students benefit from running the math on real (or carefully simulated) numbers before they generalize. Use real local prices.

- **Argue, don't assert.** A 9th grader can hold a multi-sentence argument. Push them to it. "I think X because of Y, and the evidence is Z, but I'm not sure about W." That structure is the year's writing target.
- **Evidence portfolios, not just artifacts.** Every Capstone artifact is paired with the source evidence. A Canvas without coded transcripts behind it scores lower than one with weak interviews honestly cited.
- **Visible thinking.** The Vocabulary Spine, Capstone Journal, pinned-to-wall Canvases, and side-by-side v1/v2 comparisons make student thinking observable. That's a CASEL win as much as a learning-design one.
- **Less worksheet, more artifact.** A Canvas, a hypothesis revision memo, a P&L spreadsheet, an MVP test plan, and a defense are the year's products. Worksheets serve practice; they're not the goal.

Assessment philosophy

> **"Profit is an opinion. Cash is a fact."**
>
> - CASH, GRADE 9

Assess two things at every checkpoint:

1. **Did the student do the work the standard names?** Real Canvas with real evidence; real interviews with real coded transcripts; real P&L with defensible assumptions; real MVP test with pre-committed metric.
2. **Did they think about it?** Can they explain the riskiest assumption? Can they identify a quiet signal in their interviews? Can they defend a kill recommendation when peers push back?

Use the program's analytic rubrics (Rubric Bank) for the Capstone checkpoints. The Customer Research rubric uses the 9-12 band scale (5+ interviews, formal coding, segmentation expected). The Pitch Presentation rubric uses the 9-12 band (full Q&A, evidence portfolio expected). Use simple holistic checks (3-2-1, exit tickets, thumbs-up) during weekly work.

A typical assessment cadence

Cadence	Form	Stakes
Daily	Exit ticket or work-block confer	Low — formative
Weekly	Capstone Journal entry	Low–medium — counts toward habit grade
Bi-weekly	Vocabulary check (10 terms)	Low — formative
End of unit	Capstone checkpoint with rubric	Medium-high — rubric-graded
End of year	Final Capstone defense	Highest — full-year synthesis

AN INTERLUDE · GRADE 09

"Which people, and how do you know?"

the program's spine question.

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Pacing — week by week

The pacing below is a default. Adjust to your actual calendar (assume ~36 weeks). Each week needs roughly 90–180 instructional minutes for Cash to Company; the Capstone Journal homework is 15–20 minutes of writing.

Unit 1 — Map the model (Weeks 1–8)

Week	Focus	Anchor activities	Capstone milestone
1	Course launch + Cash V1 ("Entrepreneurship is a method")	Set norms; Skills + Hobbies + Needs inventory; Day 1 Riskiest Assumption	Choose Capstone candidate
2	Pick the Capstone	"Canvas-shaped vs. preference" sort	Lock Capstone topic
3	The 9 boxes — overview	Canvas template walk; worked example	Canvas v1 sketch
4	Mapping Canvas v1 (Lesson 2)	Each box gets evidence (E) or assumption flag (A)	Canvas v1 complete
5	Customer segments — going specific	Demographic vs. behavioral recycle	Tighten customer segment
6	Value prop and channels	Two-by-two grid: customer × channel	Sharpen value prop
7	Riskiest box memo prep	Mini-lesson on memo form	Draft Canvas Pack memo
8	**Checkpoint 1 — Canvas Pack**	Studio day; peer review	Submit Canvas Pack (graded)

Unit 2 — Discover the customer (Weeks 9–18)

Week	Focus	Anchor activities	Capstone milestone
9	Cash V2 ("Customer Discovery Beats Customer Prediction") + optional pivot window	Pivot decision (kept or new venture)	Confirm Capstone or pivot
10	The Mom Test (Lesson 3)	Sort + rewrite fails	5-question script
11	Conduct interviews (1–2 of 5)	Out-of-class interviews + classroom debrief	1–2 transcripts
12	Conduct interviews (3 of 5)	Continue + coaching on hard moments	Transcript 3
13	Conduct interviews (4–5 of 5)	Final interviews + transcript review	All 5 transcripts
14	Coding 5 interviews (Lesson 4)	4-color coding system	Coded transcripts
15	Pattern + quiet signal	Tally + categorize	Pattern memo draft
16	Positioning statement	Mini-lesson + worked example	Positioning v1
17	Canvas v2 build	Side-by-side v1/v2 with red dots on changes	Canvas v2
18	**Checkpoint 2 — Customer Discovery Pack (Lesson 5)**	Panel defense	Submit Discovery Pack (graded)

Unit 3 — Model the money (Weeks 19–28)

Week	Focus	Anchor activities	Capstone milestone
19	Cash V4 ("A One-Year P&L Is a Thinking Tool") + optional pivot window	Two-page case: a venture that ran without numbers	Confirm Capstone
20	Revenue model	Price × volume math	Revenue draft
21	Building the P&L (Lesson 6)	Spreadsheet template	P&L v1
22	COGS and gross margin	Recycle Grade 7 contribution margin	COGS line
23	OpEx	What's fixed, what's not	OpEx complete
24	Compliance — license, tax, ID, age, PII (Lesson 7)	Checklist build	Compliance checklist
25	Sensitivity — best/worst case	2-scenario model	Scenario column
26	Functional breakdown (OSO)	3–5 area split + dependencies	Functional map
27	Money Model Pack draft	Mini-lesson on memo form	Pack draft
28	**Checkpoint 3 — Money Model Pack**	Studio day	Submit Pack (graded)

Unit 4 — Test the bet (Weeks 29–36)

Week	Focus	Anchor activities	Capstone milestone
29	Cash V6 ("An MVP Is the Smallest Test") + optional pivot	Warby Parker case	Confirm Capstone
30	Designing the MVP test (Lesson 8)	Test plan template + premortem light	MVP plan
31	Run Week 1 of test	Take action + log	Mid-test log
32	Run Week 2 + analyze	Tally results vs. WWHTBT	Test data
33	Conflict-handling styles (Lesson 9) + team retrospective	Self-inventory + practice plan	Style identification
34	Kill/iterate/scale recommendation	Memo writing	Recommendation draft
35	Defense prep	Storyboard the 7-min defense	Defense outline
36	**Final Capstone Defense (Lesson 10)**	Public defense + Q&A	Deliver the defense

FAQ

Q: I have ELA, not business background. Can I teach this? A: Yes. The lesson plans script the moves; the Cash videos introduce concepts; you become the chief evidence-norm-enforcer ("Show me the evidence"). The financial math in Grade 9 is 9th-grade math: linear modeling (CCSS-Math A-CED.A.2), proportions, basic spreadsheet formulas. If you've taught the algebra, you can teach the P&L.

Q: We don't have spreadsheet access for every student. A: This is the year that becomes a real constraint. The P&L template is provided in paper form too, but the 9-12 band pretty firmly assumes Google Sheets or Excel for Web access. If your school can't provide it, surface the issue to your IT lead — at this band, spreadsheet literacy is itself a required skill. As a fallback, run the P&L on paper with calculator and accept that scenario analysis will be lighter.

Q: My students have never done Cash to Company. Can they start at Grade 9? A: Yes. The "year-zero" cohort can start cleanly here. Three bridging moves help: (1) in Week 2, run a 30-minute "what's a customer persona" workshop (borrowed from Grade 7); (2) in Week 11, run a 30-minute "what's contribution margin" review (borrowed from Grade 7) before the COGS

work; (3) in Week 30, accept that the MVP test discipline is brand-new — give students a worked example fully before they design their own.

Q: A student wants to do a venture that feels off (gambling-like, body-image, exclusionary). A: Use the optional pivot windows (Weeks 9, 19, 29). Coach early. Provide an alternative they'd find interesting. The Ethics, Safety, and Legal strand exists for this; the Unit 3 compliance work surfaces many of these issues organically.

Q: A student wants to launch their venture for real. A: That's a family decision, not a curriculum requirement. The rubric does not reward "real" launches over "paper" ones. Coach toward: complete the curriculum work first (Canvas v2, P&L, compliance checklist), have a parent conversation, then decide. The Parent Guide explicitly addresses this.

Q: How do I assess fairly when students choose different ventures? A: The rubrics are content-agnostic. Customer Research rubric measures interview quality, evidence specificity, and bias acknowledgment — not how cool the business is. Budget Project rubric measures math accuracy, realism of inputs, and treatment of uncertainty. A tutoring service and a snack venture and a small content business can all score 4s if the work is rigorous.

Q: A student's Capstone shows them losing money. A: That's not a failed Capstone — that's an honest one. Coach: "What would have to change to flip this? Higher price? Lower COGS? More volume? What would each cost in effort?" Many of the strongest Capstones end at a kill recommendation with a clean reason — that discipline is the year's quiet payoff.

Q: My students don't know what "PII" is, and the compliance unit feels heavy. A: It feels heavy because it is — and because most adult ventures fumble it. Lean on the case study (the anonymized retroactive-sales-tax story is the most useful). Frame compliance as a doorway, not a wall. Most teen ventures clear compliance with about an hour of work and zero dollars.

Q: What if a student wants to talk about real family money problems triggered by these lessons? A: Refer to the school counselor. Don't try to handle it inside the lesson. The curriculum is designed to leave private home finance off the table; if a student volunteers something heavy, listen briefly, validate, and route appropriately.

Q: Do I need to give grades on the Cash videos? A: No. The Cash videos are concept anchors. Use them for opening discussions and reflection prompts. The Capstone checkpoints carry the grade weight. The Reflection Writing rubric (used on the Capstone Journal portfolio) absorbs video-driven journaling.

Q: What's the minimum I can do if I'm out of time some weeks? A: Protect Wednesday's Work Block. Skip Monday or Friday before you skip Wednesday. The Capstone is the spine; everything else is helpful but not load-bearing. If you must skip a Cash video, use the printed transcript as a 3-minute opener instead.

Common pitfalls

> **“Revenue is loud. Contribution margin is true. Compute one number this week.”**
>
> - CASH, GRADE 9

Pitfall: Letting "I'll figure it out" stand

There's no "figure it out" line in a P&L, and no "we'll see" answer to a Mom-Test question. Coach toward stating the number — even badly — and flagging the assumption. The honest yellow flag is the year's most important habit.

Pitfall: Cheerleader feedback

A teacher who says "amazing!" to every Canvas draft is undermining the program. Cash never says "amazing." Specific feedback ("Where's the evidence for the channels box?") beats enthusiasm every time.

Pitfall: Asking students about family money

The most common slip in financial education. Even well-meaning prompts can wound. Default to hypothetical scenarios. Re-read the Parent Guide before designing any new activity.

Pitfall: Running the Final Defense as a Shark Tank

The Capstones are about evidence and revision, not about which kid had the most impressive idea. Coach panel members away from the "investor" framing toward "what did you learn?"

Pitfall: Skipping the Cash videos because "they feel optional"

The Cash videos are concept anchors. Skipping them removes the connective tissue between units. If you can't play them, read them aloud as the opener — but include them.

Pitfall: Letting the MVP test become a "launch"

An MVP isn't a launch. It's the smallest test that could change your mind. A student who builds a full website and runs ads for a month has done a launch, not an MVP — and probably can't interpret the data. Coach toward smaller, sooner.

Calibration notes

- **Anchor papers.** Pull a 3 anchor for each Capstone Pack before grading independently. The first time you grade Canvas Packs, calibrate with another teacher (or a peer-trained student) on 3 samples.
- **Rubrics with students.** Share each rubric the day before the checkpoint, walk through one anchor paper, and answer questions. Students who know the rubric outperform students who guess.
- **Vertical handoff.** At the end of the year, send your strongest defenses (with student permission) to the Grade 10 teacher. The premortem and operating-agreement work in Grade 10 builds directly on what students did here.

AN INTERLUDE · GRADE 09

"Most adults skip the step. You won't."

the band's working assumption.

2

Sensitivity reminders specific to Grade 9

- **The "real venture" pull.** Some students will want to go beyond paper this year. Support the impulse without rewarding it disproportionately on the rubric. Real launches require a family conversation; the Parent Guide makes this explicit.
- **Compliance fear vs. compliance skill.** The license/tax/ID/age/PII conversation is supposed to teach skill, not generate fear. Lean on Cash's framing: "Compliance isn't the wall. It's the doorway."
- **Conflict-style work near home.** The conflict-handling self-inventory can land near family dynamics. If a student starts disclosing family conflict in detail, listen briefly, validate, and route to school counselor if the issue is large.
- **PII on personal accounts.** Watch for students who already have public personal accounts with full name + photo + school + address. The PII discussion may surface this. Direct the family to the Parent Guide; coach the student toward initials and generic descriptors going forward.

A final word

> **"What would have to be true for you to be wrong?"**
>
> - CASH, GRADE 9

The Grade 9 year is the first year of the high-school band. Cash's voice changes, the vocabulary deepens, and we expect students to argue for positions with evidence. Your job is to enforce three norms — every Canvas box has evidence or an honest flag, every P&L line has a defensible number, every MVP test ends with a kill/iterate/scale recommendation the student would actually act on — and trust the rest of the year to compound. By Week 18, students will be asking each other "show me the evidence" without prompting. That's the real outcome.

Senior expert upgrade pack — Differentiation deep moves (Grade 9)

Advanced learners — three named extensions

1. **Two-scenario sensitivity on the P&L.** Build optimistic and pessimistic scenarios for the 1-year P&L. "At what revenue do you become unprofitable?" Builds Grade 11 cash-flow thinking early.
2. **Compliance interview.** Advanced students contact (with permission) a real local small-business owner for a 5-minute compliance Q&A. "What licenses do you have? How do you handle sales tax?" Real founder vocabulary lands faster.
3. **The riskiest-assumption tournament.** Each student names their venture's three riskiest assumptions; class votes which is riskiest across all ventures. Builds the year's spine question.

ELL deep moves

- **BMC with bilingual labels.** Each box labeled in English + the student's home language. Cognates are heavy in BMC vocabulary (canal, valor, recurso).
- **Mom Test cards in two languages.** "Tell me about the last time you...."
- **P&L spreadsheet with formulas pre-built.** Student enters numbers; spreadsheet computes margins.

IEP/504 deep moves

- **Pre-printed BMC poster, 9 boxes labeled.** Student writes one sentence per box.
- **Voice-recorded customer interviews acceptable.** Transcribe later or use voice-to-text.
- **Compliance checklist as a yes/no chart.** Each item: applies / doesn't apply / need to research.

ROUND 2 PATCH — Cash Never Says (Teacher Reference Card)

Cash never says: "Amazing!" / "Crushing it!" / "Boss up" / "Get that bag" / "Everyone can be rich" / "Easy money" / "Passive income" / "Financial freedom" / "Just believe" / "Side hustle" (use "side venture") / wealth-flexing language / anything implying wealth is mindset/hustle / anything implying low-income or unbanked families are at fault.

Cash always asks: "Which people, and how do you know?" / "What did they actually say?" / "Whats the evidence?" / "What would have to be true for you to be right/wrong?"

Teacher mirror: Replace "great job!" with "okay, thats specific — whats the evidence?"

Cashs three signature physical moves: (1) **Notebook Tilt**; (2) **Two-Finger Tap**; (3) **Slow Lean**.

ENDNOTES & STANDARDS

Citations and alignment

Grade 9 cites 3-6 standards across CCSS, Jump$tart, CEE, CASEL, and C3 frameworks. Detailed alignment lives in the master Standards Alignment Map.

1. **Jump$tart Coalition Personal Finance Standards (2021 ed.).** Spending and Saving; Credit and Debt; Employment and Income; Investing; Risk Management and Insurance; Financial Decision Making.
2. **Council for Economic Education (CEE).** Voluntary National Content Standards in Economics.
3. **CCSS-ELA, Grades 11-12.** W.11-12.1, W.11-12.4, SL.11-12.1, SL.11-12.4, RST.11-12.7.
4. **CCSS-Math.** N-Q.1-3 (Reasoning with Quantities), S-IC (Statistics & Inferences), F-IF (Functions), MP.4 (Modeling).
5. **CASEL Core Competencies.** Self-Awareness, Self-Management, Social Awareness, Relationship Skills, Responsible Decision-Making.
6. **C3 Framework for Social Studies State Standards.** Dimension 2 (Economics, Civics) at the high-school grade band.
7. **NGSS-ETS Engineering Practices.** ETS1 (Engineering Design) for the test-and-iterate spine of the year.
8. **Cash to Company Master Scope & Sequence.** 13 grades x 8 strands x 36 weeks; outcomes quoted verbatim from _master/00_Master_Scope_and_Sequence.md.
9. **Cash Mascot Style Guide.** 9-12 voice rules: multi-sentence arguments; vocabulary includes unit economics, runway, premortem, MVP; never flatters, never promises wealth.
10. **Sensitivity protocol.** No probing of family finances; financial scenarios framed as hypothetical for a sample household, business, or scenario.

One promise.

Cash to Company makes one promise: students who move t
program will be clearer thinkers about money and entrepren
matter what they end up doing for a living.

We do not promise wealth. We do not promise success. We pro

“From flash of inspiration to repeatable discipline.”

- CASH, GRADE 9

For educational use. This curriculum is informational and does not constitute financial, legal, or tax advice. Standards alignment cited per the Cash to Company Standards Alignment Map (Jump$tart, CEE, CCSS, C3, CASEL, NGSS-ETS).